

HelpMap — find help in your community, in plain language

WarriorHacks 2.0 — Theme: solve an issue in your community

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Purpose

Every community has resources — food banks, free clinics, shelters, ESL classes, legal aid — but the people who need them most often can't find them: scattered PDFs, bureaucratic language, English-only websites. A stressed parent looking for free food tonight doesn't need a search engine; they need a warm, direct answer: **where, when, what to bring**. HelpMap turns a community's own resource guide into a navigator that answers in plain language — cited to the guide, read aloud, and honest about what it doesn't know.

Key features

- **Guide ingestion** — upload the community's resource guide (PDF / TXT / MD); every organization keeps its exact source.
- **Quick help buttons** — Food · Health · Shelter · ESL · Legal: one tap answers the most urgent needs.
- **Warm, practical answers** — organization, address, hours, languages, and what to bring (including "no ID required"), cited to the exact line.
- **Spoken answers** — neural TTS reads every answer aloud; accessible for low-vision and low-literacy users.
- **Browse mode** — the whole guide by category, with an Ask-about-this button on every organization.
- **Honest refusals** — needs the guide doesn't cover get an explicit refusal. An invented address is worse than no answer.
- **Emergency first** — danger or medical emergencies are routed to 911 before anything else.

Safety & dignity by design: answers come only from the uploaded guide; no invented addresses or phone numbers, ever. The tone is warm and non-judgmental, and the app surfaces when no ID, no registration, or no documents are required — the questions people are afraid to ask. The bundled guide ("Springfield") is entirely fictional.

How it works

Python + FastAPI backend; single-page web UI (no build step). Guide ingestion keeps source-linked passages; a browse endpoint parses the guide into categorized organizations. Retrieval is scikit-learn TF-IDF (local, any language); generation is retrieval-scoped with mandatory citations and an explicit refusal token. Audio uses edge-tts with content-hash caching. Any OpenAI-compatible LLM endpoint can be configured.

Impact

- **Access** — the people who need help most get direct, actionable answers.
- **Language** — audio + plain language lower barriers for non-native speakers and low-literacy users.
- **Trust** — cited answers and honest refusals make the tool safe to rely on.
- **Reusability** — any community can deploy it with their own guide: the data is a file, the app is free.

[python](#) [fastapi](#) [scikit-learn](#) [edge-tts](#) [LLM](#) [RAG](#) [community](#)

Demo video: youtu.be/OVDilJSLxIQ (unlisted) · Code: github.com/maebaheioru/helpmap

HelpMap is not a medical device and is not for emergencies. Always consult a qualified clinician.